were less inclined to treat Russia as a future superpower that deserved exceptions to the rules.[129]

Pursuit of Autonomy and Protecting Against Infringements on Russia's Sovereignty

Moscow's foremost aversion—to infringements on Russia's autonomy and national sovereignty—is a driving force behind Russia's expectations for the BRICS' collective financial statecraft. The lessons from the experience of two major economic shocks, followed by the global financial crisis and a fourth economic shock coinciding with a plunge in oil prices and the value of the Russian ruble and the imposition of Western sanctions, reinforced such aversions. It informs Moscow's interest in strengthening the club's voice in incumbent institutions and increasing the development of emerging-market financial institutions and currencies. It also contributes to several unilateral Russian policies, notably maintaining the large stockpile of foreign currency reserves, diminishing the dominance of the dollar while also increasing the regional (and global) role of the ruble, and creating new financial institutions (e.g., alternative national payments systems and non-Western credit rating agencies) that bolster Russia's autonomy from U.S. structural power while boosting its own global influence in ways that speed the emergence of multipolarity.

Paradoxically, post-Soviet Russia's self-defined requirement for a war chest of foreign currency reserves is necessitated first and foremost by its rejection of autarky. Russian leaders have largely embraced markets and globalization, albeit in their own way, which has meant that globalization is filtered through a political economy saturated with crony capitalism and, in Putin's second and third terms, a pronounced shift toward state capitalism.[130] It is also worth remembering that when Putin assumed power in 1999, Russia had less than $13 billion in hard currency reserves and faced $133 billion of foreign debt. After the devaluation of the ruble following the 1998 debt crisis, the first Putin term oversaw the enactment of reforms crafted by Putin's economic adviser German Gref, including of the tax system and business regulations stimulating a new class of entrepreneurs.[131]

As a share of gross domestic product (GDP), government expenditure declined to 36 percent in 2006, the same year that exchange rates were fully